APPENDIX 2

I Can't Look It up!

Ruby has a lot of notation and typography that is called by a name that is not necessarily obvious, making it hard to search for the meaning of a particular line of code. Here are a few particularly important symbols:

Symbol	Name	Functionality
`||=`	or-equals	Like other Ruby operate and assign operators. `x ||= y` is equivalent to `x = x || y`. Because of Ruby's short circuit of boolean operators, the expression means that if x is nil, the new value is y, and if x is not nil, then x's value remains the same. Is often used as a shortcut to set a default value.
`=~ !~`	Match operators	With a string on one side of the operator, and a regular epression on the other, `=~` returns true if the string matches the regular expression and `!~` returns true if the string doesn't match the regular expression.
`%i()`	symbol delimiter, symbol percent literals.	Takes a set of barewords and converts them to an array of symbols, `%i[a b c]` becomes `[:a, :b, :c]`. The delimiter after the `%i` is arbitrary, the array continues until the matching delimiter is encountered at the end of the expression.
`%w()`	array delimiter, array percent literals.	Takes a set of barewords and converts them to an array of strings, `%w[a b c]` becomes `["a", "b", "c"]`. The delimiter after the `%w` is arbitrary, the array continues until the matching delimiter is encountered at the end of the expression.
`%q()` or `%Q()`	string delimiter, string percent literals.	Acts as a literal string delimiter, lower case q acts as a single quote string, upper case Q acts as a double quote string. Usually used to avoid escaping if the quote mark is part of the string. The delimiter is arbitrary, the string continues until the matching delimiter is encountered.
`%r()`	regular expression delimiter, regular expression percent literals.	Acts as a literal regular expression delimiter. Usually used to avoid escaping if the / is part of the regular expression. The delimiter after the r is arbitrary, the string continues until the matching delimiter is encountered.